



HIGH winds and big waves didn't deter some people from enjoying a day last week at Zuma Beach in Malibu. ROBERT GAUTHIER Los Angeles Times

Trump's pressure plan for Iran may backfire

New U.S. strategy for economic isolation could have no effect or prompt retaliation.

By ERIC MARTIN

President Trump is betting new sanctions, a naval blockade and ramped-up economic pressure against Iran's trading partners can accomplish what thousands of bombs and missiles could not: force Tehran to accept a deal to end the war on U.S. terms.

But like other U.S. efforts to force Iran into capitulation, there's one main problem: Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps, which has claimed control of the vital Strait of Hormuz and sent volleys of attack drones across the Persian Gulf, may be impervious to such pressure — and has plenty of ways to retaliate.

A key part of the U.S. effort will come Monday, when Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent is to unveil details of a plan designed to shift the conflict from tit-for-tat strikes across the Middle East to full-blown economic isolation — a campaign that could touch nations ranging from China and India to Turkey and the United Arab Emirates.

Yet significant new economic pressure is likely to prompt Iran to retaliate with military strikes across the gulf — including against en-

[See Iran, A3]

No 'capitulation,' Iran leader says

The president defends the memorandum of understanding signed with the U.S. **WORLD, A3**

EL NIÑO IS HERE. FEARS ARE RISING

Early signs point to higher sea levels, and king tides may compound the problem this winter

By Rong-Gong Lin II

A rare convergence of a powerful El Niño, super king tides and sea level rise spurred by climate change could menace California with record coastal flooding this winter.

Already, officials are observing higher tides than typical. Swells are eroding beaches, damaging parking lots and bathrooms, and even resurfacing long-buried coastal infrastructure.

And that's before El Niño even kicks into high gear.

Jonathan Warrick, a research geologist with the U.S. Geological Survey, said that the climate pattern — commonly viewed as a rainmaker in Southern California — also turbocharges the sea.

"There's a phenomenon during El Niños where the waters offshore California get warmer, and they actually rise up, up to a foot, sometimes more, higher than average," he said.

That may not seem like much, but it's more than enough to wreak havoc on lower-lying homes and coastal infrastructure. Over the past 125 years, the average sea level in San Francisco Bay, for example, has already risen by about 1 foot — an increase experts link to human-caused climate change.

"Folks who really think about coastal risks are very concerned that the single-highest sea levels on record are quite possible this winter in California," said Daniel Swain, a UC climate scientist. "And that is going to be a problem."

This pattern has happened before. During the "very strong" El Niños of 1982-83 and 1997-98, as well as the "strong" El Niño of 2023-24, San Francisco Bay logged record monthly average sea levels.

"The fact that our seas will be higher than average is a very concerning factor for

[See El Niño, A9]

ADAPTATION: Florida learns ways to cope with rising sea levels. **NATION, A5**

NASA's high-stakes helicopter mission

Visit to Saturn's moon Titan is the last planned endeavor of its kind

By ERIC NILER



STEVE GRIBBEN NASA/Johns Hopkins Applied Physics Laboratory

AN ARTIST'S rendering of the nuclear-powered Dragonfly, which is set to gather samples on Titan.

LAUREL, Md. — Ralph Lorenz dreamed up the idea of flying a helicopter through Titan's thick, methane-tinged atmosphere back in 2000 in a speculative research paper and a cover story for New Scientist magazine.

"It was a fantasy," Lorenz said.

A quarter of a century later, that fantasy is turning into reality inside a 40-foot-tall clean room at the Johns Hopkins University Applied Physics Laboratory just outside the Washington Beltway. The Dragonfly spacecraft, a \$3.3-billion nuclear-powered space-copter, has survived a decade of uncertain budgets and a shift in NASA priorities to become the space agency's last, large-scale planetary science mission, scheduled to blast off in July 2028, bound for Saturn's largest moon.

To meet that launch window, technicians in protective suits test electronics on the spacecraft's chassis, which resembles a gray metal box with four out-

[See Dragonfly, A7]

HOLLYWOOD IN CRISIS

Lights, camera, inaction: L.A.'s movie exodus

Hubris, high costs, political failings and competition driving industry's flight.

By STACY PERMAN

It was a television show tailor-made for Los Angeles: a highly anticipated Netflix crime drama about a team of ex-special forces operators who outsource their skills to criminals in the city.

The production was backed by a prominent indie studio and had a critically acclaimed lead actor attached. And with a budget of more than \$100 million and a crew of 350, the series seemed like a shoo-in for California's film tax and TV credit.

But last month, shortly before filming was set to begin, producers were stunned to learn the film didn't make the cut based on a formula the state uses to rank projects by the number of jobs they produce and their spending levels. After two applications for a tax credit had been rejected, they opted to shoot the series in New Jersey, where it was much easier to qualify for film incentives.

"We were shocked," said a producer on the project who

declined to be identified because of the sensitivity of the matter. "This is the birthplace of entertainment. It shouldn't be so hard to shoot here."

Despite improvements to the state's tax incentive program, Los Angeles and California continue to struggle to keep movies, television series and even game shows from fleeing elsewhere. Production levels have failed to bounce back since the pandemic and the labor strikes by writers and actors, and they remain at historic lows.

Film activity in the L.A. region plummeted in the second quarter of this year, with shoot days for feature films and TV productions falling 20% and 30%, respectively, compared with already anemic levels from a year ago, according to FilmLA.

The fallout has been devastating for local film crews and businesses. L.A.'s signature industry has shed some 57,000 jobs in the past four years, while more than 80 film and television production services businesses have closed since 2022. The production crisis has even become a political flashpoint alongside affordability, crime and homelessness in the race for mayor and governor.

[See Hollywood, A6]

Federal cuts aim to stem crisis on Colorado River

California ordered to curb water use by 12%. Arizona, Nevada face steeper reductions.

By IAN JAMES

The Colorado River, a critical water lifeline for seven states, has shrunk dramatically. And the nation's largest reservoirs, Lake Mead and Lake Powell, have dropped to their lowest levels on record.

In an effort to prevent the reservoirs from reaching critically low levels, the Trump administration has released a plan that orders substantial water cutbacks in California, Arizona and Nevada over the next two years and outlines possible larger cuts if deemed necessary over the next decade.

The Interior Department has accepted an offer the three states made to reduce the amount of water they take from the river by about 3.2 million acre-feet between now and the end of 2028.

California will cut its use of Colorado River water by about 12%, while Arizona will take about 31% less and Nevada 28% less.

"We've been in this 26-year prolonged drought period," said Andrea Travnicke, the Interior Department's assistant secretary for water and science. "We continue to see a prolonged drought in our future. So continuing to work together as a whole within the basin is going to be extremely important."

The Interior Department on Friday issued a document called a record of decision detailing its 10-year plan for dealing with the water shortages. If reservoir levels continue to fall, it allows for larger mandatory water cuts of up to 3 million acre-feet per year in California, Arizona and Nevada — as much as 40% of their combined allotments.

The Trump administration did not mention climate change in its announcement. But extensive research shows global warming, driven by the use of fossil fuels and other emissions of planet-heating gases, is intensifying the extremely dry conditions.

Since 2020, the river flow has averaged 32% less than in the 20th century.

The federal government was required to set new rules

[See Water, A9]

California indie publishers thrive

Far from New York, distinctive literary houses rise

By CAROLYN KELLOGG

When the Booker Prize longlist was recently announced, it included a book with the memorable title "May We Feed the King."

The debut novel by British author Rebecca Perry isn't yet available in the U.S., and when it does hit shelves, it will be coming from Transit Books, a small Bay Area publisher run by the husband-and-wife team Adam Z. Levy and Ashley Nelson Levy.

Cited by the Booker committee as "a playful, stirring meditation on history and storytelling" about a curator and a king, the book "has been an early favorite with indie booksellers," Ashley says.

"We knew the book was special when we acquired it," Adam adds. "Ever since, we've been crossing our fingers and knocking on wood and sending up flares to the Booker gods, and sent the book to the printer a little earlier than usual just in case."

Transit, known for publishing intelligent international fiction, began about a decade ago, when Ashley and Adam were convinced that great works of literature were being passed over by New York publishers, and that those books should have a place in America.

There were, Adam says, "really great authors who might have incredible reputations elsewhere not finding publishing houses here that are able to champion them in a way that gets them

[See Publishers, A7]

Survivors of rap's deadly gang war

In the 1990s, they were soldiers in a conflict that claimed many lives, notably that of Tupac Shakur. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Immigrants' story writ large

Activist Dolores Huerta helps trace the history of mass deportations in a Sacramento exhibit. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

Weather
Record-tying heat.
L.A. Basin: 96/72. **B5**



KAYLA BARTKOWSKI Los Angeles Times

STANDOFF INTENSIFIES

Paramount's dustup with Mark Ruffalo heats up as the actor is accused of using "antisemitic tropes" ahead of mediation talks. **BUSINESS, A10**